

## Chapter 2: Progeny

### Eric, 20 Years Ago

“Eric!” The voice calling out from below the tower belonged to Eric’s best friend, Flavio. “Your wife is here, and there’s no way I’m covering for you again. Go home!” The incident he was likely referring to was Eric and Nerys’s wedding, where Flavio had been his best man—and had also been responsible for stalling Nerys until Eric got there. Even on their special day, he’d still been late. He’d never had a good grasp of time to be honest.

Eric sighed and began to climb down from the tower. On the grounds below, amidst training dummies and equipment, a pair of individuals stuck out amongst the normal guards—a large, dark-skinned man next to a crate of freshly-repaired weapons and a pale half-elven woman almost half his size wearing a beautiful white sundress and a wide-brimmed hat to match. Even after being together for a few years now, he still thought she looked radiant. His fatigue—which he hadn’t even realized had begun to set in—instantly vanished, and a smile broke out across his face.

“Wow, Flavio. Where’d you find such a beauty in a town like this?” Eric’s attempt at a joke elicited an eye roll from Flavio, while Nerys immediately averted her eyes to hide her blushing face behind her hat; unfortunately for her, Eric had spent his life trying to be perceptive, so he caught it immediately.

“Oh, stop it. I just ran into him on the way to come get *you*. Your shift was supposed to be over an hour ago.” Nerys tried to put an angry tone into her voice, but she was still flustered and couldn’t make it very convincing. Eric laughed, a wholehearted laugh that shook his body. One of the other guards nearby gestured to Flavio, who waved to Eric and Nerys as he went over to check in the delivery.

“I know, I know. But if I wasn’t late, you’d be worried too! Being late is a part of who I am, just as much as being radiant is part of who you are. Besides, if it wasn’t, we’d never have met!” It was true; on the day Nerys had approached Eric, he’d been almost two hours late to take his lunch break, which meant the shifts had changed at the distributary. It had been the only time his tardiness had actually been a good thing, and it changed both their lives for the better.

“I know. Normally, I wouldn’t mind as much, but...” She reached a hand down to her belly, which had grown larger in recent months. “We were supposed to decide on her name today.” *Oops*, Eric thought. *Forgot about that*. Eric reached over and took his wife’s other hand.

“You’re right. I’m sorry. Hmm...” He paused to think for a moment. “What about Valkyrie? Or Victoria?”

“I don’t know, to be honest. I’m not sure either of those feels... right. They sound strong, capable. Like a warrior. If she takes after you, then that might be alright, but... I’m worried she’ll be more like me. Maybe we should consider a gentler name, like Nia or Misha.” Eric looked at her approvingly.

“I like Nia; we should start with that, though I think we could get away with giving her a middle name that sounds strong—be a bit more hopeful, you know? This city could use some more optimism. Of course, there’s also the chance she ends up being a boy instead, so maybe we should consider some names for that too.” Eric paused to let his words sink in. “Anyway, this is more of a conversation for home. Let me go grab my stuff, and we’ll head home.”

With that, Eric kissed his wife on the cheek and returned up the tower. As he packed up his stuff, he couldn’t help but glance over into the darkness. Just outside the barrier, all was quiet, though he could swear he saw some movement just beyond his vision—shifting shadows, just so subtly swaying.

*You can’t protect them.*

Eric shook his head, dismissing the noise, before he headed back down to walk his wife home with a smile.